

The first macro virus went by the name “Concept” and it was pretty unchallenged. Concept soon proliferated to thousands, if not millions of computers in no time at all. Data exchange in the MS Word was now an industry standard, to get infected by Concept, one only needed to open a colleague’s file, soon all the documents edited by this newly infected copy of Word would become carriers and the spiral would continue. Adding fuel to this fire was a little thing called the Internet. The reality of infecting frequently used files at the speed of the Internet became one of the most serious problems in computing history.

With time, other macro viruses came to place. In the summer of 1996, there appeared the “Laroux” virus, infecting Microsoft Excel spreadsheets. As it had been with “Concept”, these new virus were discovered almost simultaneously by several companies. Of course, tracing the history of viruses, macro virus construction sets soon began to appear, giving rise to newer and more dangerous kinds of viruses. In the beginning of 1997 came the first polymorphic macro virus for MS Word and the first viruses for Microsoft Office97. The number of macro viruses also increased steadily reaching several hundreds by the summer of 1997. As problematic as macro viruses were—and they are a big problem—macros were not the sole attack vectors.

Threats, Threats Everywhere!

Macro viruses were not the only new threat in 1995. With the rise of the popularity of the Internet, hackers made their presence felt. The Internet gave a lot of opportunities to hackers everywhere. There were all these unsecured servers running important websites and containing vital information just waiting to be hacked. No one was prepared and the hackers took advantage of it. Hacking soon became the next ‘cool’ thing, with every teenager trying desperately to learn it to impress his friends.

Hackers attacked the Griffith Air Force Base, the Korean Atomic Research Institute, NASA’s Goddard Space Flight Center near Washington DC, and its Jet Propulsion Laboratory. Even GE, IBM,